

Features

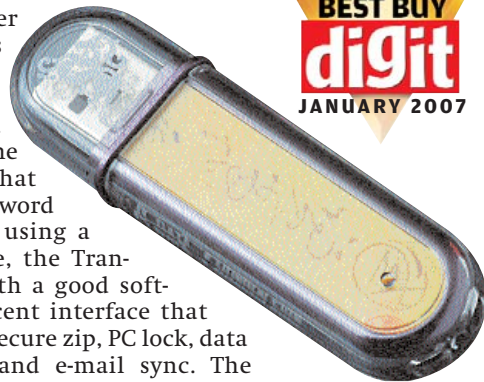
Though at the bottom of the drive pyramid, some of these drives came with decent features—the SanDisk Cruiser Micro 512 MB, for example, was the only drive in this category to support U3. Its cousin, the Cruiser Profile 512 MB, comes with a biometric scanner so your critical data is protected. While most drives come with a software CD that allows you to set a password or set partition sizes using a rudimentary interface, the Transcend drive comes with a good software package and decent interface that includes features like secure zip, PC lock, data backup, auto login, and e-mail sync. The SanDisk Cruiser Mini comes with the U3 versions of Avast!, Skype (with one month of free voice mail), SignupShield Passwords, and its own PC synchronisation software—standard features on all their drives. The Intex 512 MB also doubles up as an SD card.

Build Quality And Bundle

With its chewing-gum-like looks, Kingston's DataTraveler Mini MB was the cutest of the lot. A-DATA's Oriental Elite has a beautiful design and allows you to change faceplates (two are provided with the drive). It also includes a USB extension cable. The SanDisk Cruiser Profile 512 MB has rugged build quality and small rubber strips at the bottom to protect it from scratches. The Cruiser Micro's retracting USB connector is good for people who tend to lose their drive's cap, but is also a veritable dust-trap.

Performance

Since these drives will mostly be used to carry documents and presentations, data transfer speed is critical. The A-DATA Oriental Elite 512 MB was the fastest of the lot and took little more than 11 seconds to transfer 50 MB of files, which included documents, spreadsheets, pictures, MP3s, and



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A-DATA Oriental Elite
Blazing fast and looks good too!



SanDisk Cruiser Profile 512 MB
As secure as it gets

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executables. The TECH-COM 512 MB took a decent 27.6 seconds. Though it took just 30 seconds for the A-DATA Oriental Elite to transfer a sequential file to its full capacity. The Zion followed closely with a time of 50.3 seconds. The SanDisk Cruiser Micro took a somewhat sluggish 76 seconds.

In Sum

The A-DATA Oriental Elite takes Gold not only for its speed, but also thanks to a decent package bundle. Both the Cruiser Micro and the Profile from SanDisk put up a decent performance and have a good bundle. The Silver-winning Cruiser Profile, with its biometric scanner, is highly recommended for those who deal with sensitive data. Special mention goes to the Zion drive—though it lost out on features, it's quite fast and costs around 30 per cent less than most other Flash drives in this category.

1 GB DRIVES

This category witnessed a total of 22 drives fighting for top spot—five from PQI, three each from SanDisk, Transcend and UMAX, two from Corsair, and one each from Gigabyte, iball, Lexar, Odyssey, Transcend and Zion. These drives let you do more than just carry your documents around—you can even pack a DivX movie along with your other data. They tend to be slower than their 512 MB counterparts, however, as there is a trade-off between speed and capacity.

How We Tested

Our test bed used an Intel Core 2 Duo Extreme E6800 on an ECS PX1 Extreme Motherboard with 1 GB of Kingston HyperX DDR2 RAM. The hard drive was clean-formatted before loading Windows XP, and all the latest drivers for the motherboard and USB ports were loaded. To maintain a standard environment, we installed only the required benchmarking utilities and the files we used in our tests.

Test Methodology

All the storage devices we tested were evaluated on the basis of their scores in three primary areas, namely Features, Performance, and Price. To help in our calculations, we assigned a relevant weightage (refer table for the breakup) to these parameters.

The parameters included are:

Features

We looked at the various inbuilt characteristics such as U3 or password protection. We also observed the build quality, with primary importance given to the sturdiness of the product. We gave extra points for any security features such as biometric protection, and also for any useful software in the package.

Performance

To gauge performance, we conducted two types of tests—synthetic and real-world. For the synthetic tests, we used the HD Tach 3 benchmarking suite to assess theoretical read and write speeds, as well as the average access time. Due to the varying storage capacities of the models, we also carried out an additional test, where the thumb drive was filled to capacity with both sequential (a single large file) as well as assorted data. We observed the time taken for each transfer, and then calculated the actual data transfer rate in terms of megabytes transferred per second.